POSC 3710: European Politics

10/26/2026: HOW GOVERNMENTS FORM

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Happening now: Sweden is waiting for a government

The Riksdag elected on September 13, 2026: 349 seats

The left bloc 176	The right bloc 173
Social Democrats, Left Party, Greens, Centre Party	Moderates, Sweden Democrats, Christian Democrats, Liberals

WHY 176 IS NOT ENOUGH

- The Centre Party will not back a government that depends on the far left
- The Left Party wants seats in the cabinet

Rules

- The speaker proposes a prime minister, who takes office unless 175 members vote no
- Four failed proposals: a new election



Magdalena Andersson, leader of the Social Democrats and prime minister in 2021–22. On September 28 she gave up her first attempt to form a government. Lost a vote 10/15.

The latest:

Coalition Bargaining

- A party without a majority of the seats cannot elect a prime minister alone
- Usually the largest party gets the first chance to form a coalition
  - If it fails, the next party tries
- Smaller parties bargain for specific concessions and specific ministries
- If no government can be formed, there is a new election



Pedro Sánchez, prime minister of Spain. In 2019 no government could be formed, and Spain voted twice

Accounts of how coalitions form

OFFICE

Parties want power

- They build the smallest coalition that wins
- They split the cabinet in proportion to seats
- Implication: Take any party out, and the majority is gone

POLICY

Parties want policy

- They build coalitions of ideological neighbors
- The party in the middle sets the terms
- The test: the partners sit side by side, from left to right

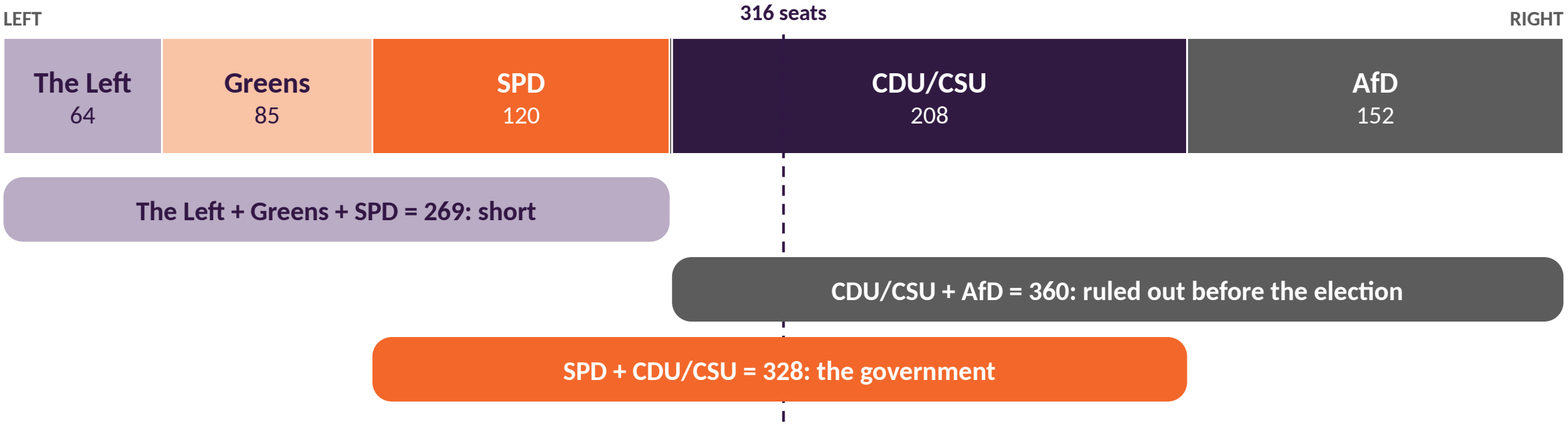
SOMETHING MESSIER

Neither explains it all

- Personalities, mistakes and deadlines
- Parties that refuse to sit with each other

Germany 2025: build a majority

630 seats, so 316 make a majority. Which coalitions of neighbors get there?



The smallest coalition that wins: yes. Neighbors: yes. The only two-party majority without the AfD: yes.

All three accounts fit this case, so it cannot choose between them.

"Friedrich Merz has repeatedly ruled out forming a coalition with the far-right party." Merz, the leader of the CDU, has been chancellor since May 2025.

Types of Government

MINIMUM WINNING

Just enough parties for a majority

- What we expect if parties care only about power: fewer partners, more ministries each
- Germany today: CDU/CSU and SPD

OVERSIZED

More parties than a majority needs

- More stable: no single partner can bring the government down
- Finland: a show of unity next to the Soviet Union
- Italy: a buffer, when members voted by secret ballot

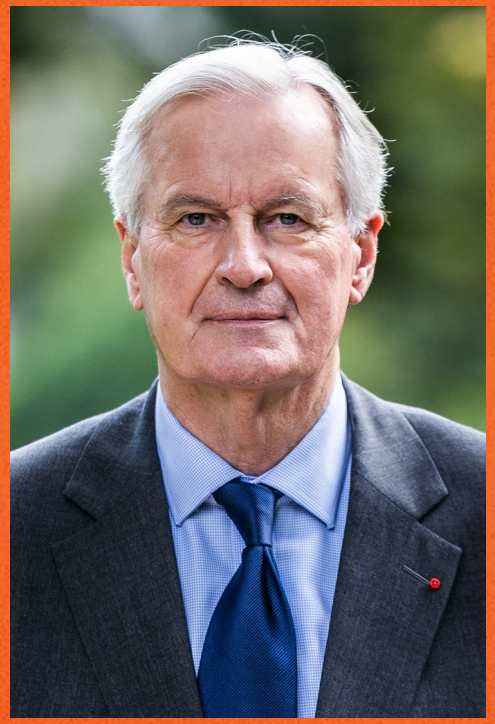
MINORITY

Fewer than half the seats

- Survives on other parties' votes, one deal at a time
- The Netherlands today: 66 of 150 seats

Which did the FRC form?

Minority Governments





Michel Barnier and François Bayrou, prime ministers of France. Both led minority governments, and the National Assembly removed both within nine months

- Governing with fewer than half the seats
- Not possible everywhere: some parliaments must vote a new government in (an investiture vote)
- Attractive to the governing party: rule alone, avoid hard compromises
  - But why would the other parties allow it?
- Often fragile

From today's reading: van Kessel and Zaslove

The Dutch Election: Not Quite a Return to the Center

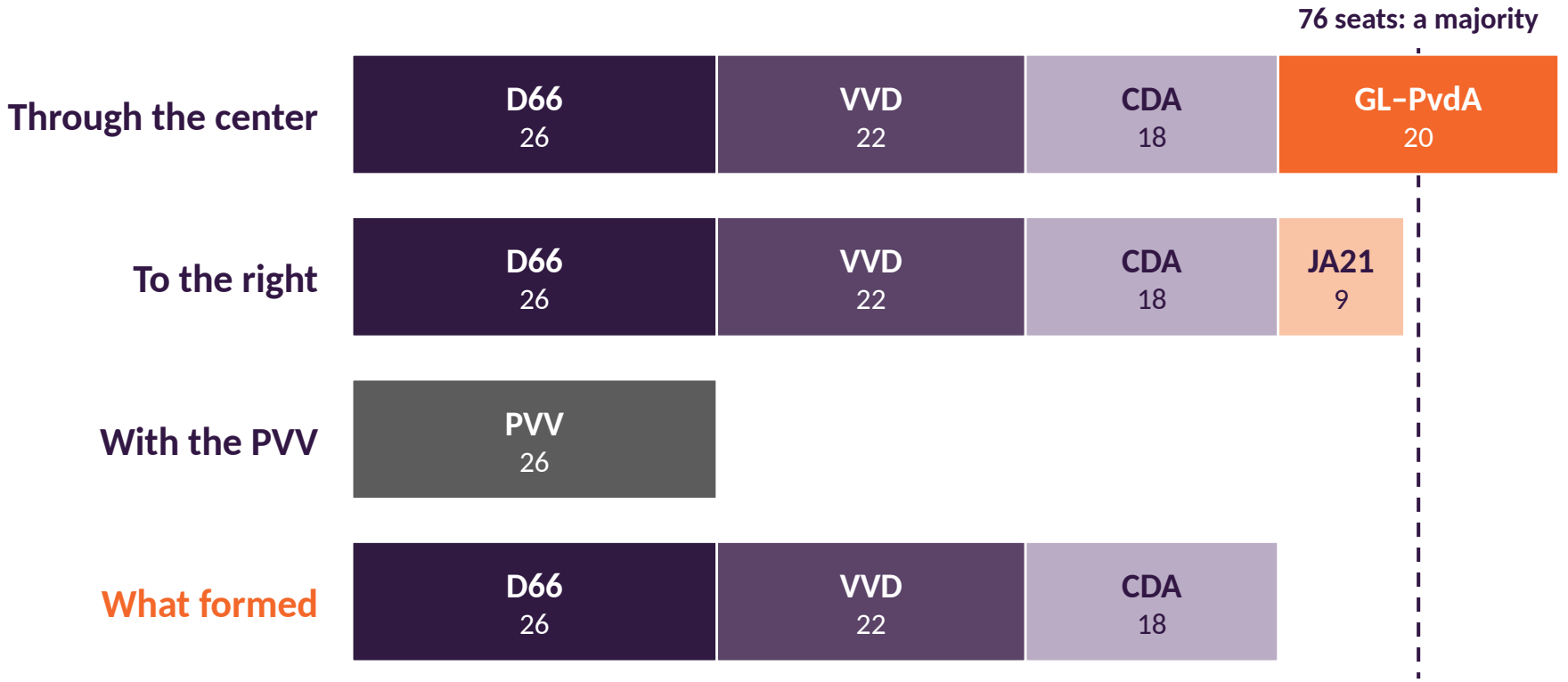


Geert Wilders, leader of the PVV, on the front page of De Telegraaf in January 2017

- October 29, 2025: D66, a liberal party of the center, finishes first
- The PVV of Geert Wilders, on the radical right, falls from 37 seats to 26
- But the far-right bloc holds 42 seats, against 41 before
- The left: "no more than 30 seats"
- "The core message of the far right has entered the mainstream of Dutch politics."

The Netherlands: how do you get to 76 seats?

Imagine you lead D66, the largest party, with 26 of 150 seats. The broad coalition or the narrow one?



86 seats. The VVD refused to govern with GL–PvdA, the alliance of the left.

75 seats: "one seat short."

Ruled out by "most other parties."

66 seats: a minority government, sworn in after 117 days.



Rob Jetten of D66 has been prime minister since February 2026. His cabinet is ten seats short, and in September it was still looking for votes to pass its first budget.

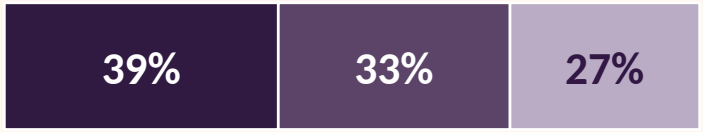
Who Gets What?

- Parties join coalitions for control of the policies they care about
  - Greens want the environment; the populist right, immigration; agrarians, agriculture
- Often several parties want the same ministry
  - It goes to the party with the most leverage: its “walk-away value”
- A rule of thumb: ministries in proportion to seats

Guess the cabinet: seats in, ministries out

THE NETHERLANDS, 2026

SHARE OF THE COALITION'S SEATS



D66 26 · VVD 22 · CDA 18

18 ministers. How many for each party?

SEATS IN THE CABINET



7, 6 and 5: almost exactly their shares

GERMANY, 2025

SHARE OF THE COALITION'S SEATS



CDU/CSU 208 · SPD 120

18 in the cabinet. How many for the SPD?

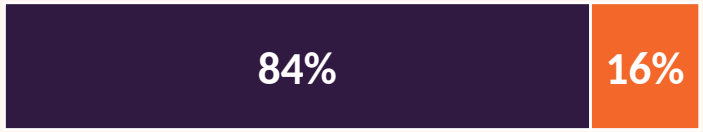
SEATS IN THE CABINET



7 of 18: 39% of the cabinet with 37% of the seats

BRITAIN, 2010

SHARE OF THE COALITION'S SEATS



Conservatives 306 · Liberal Democrats 57

23 in the cabinet. How many for the Liberal Democrats?

SEATS IN THE CABINET



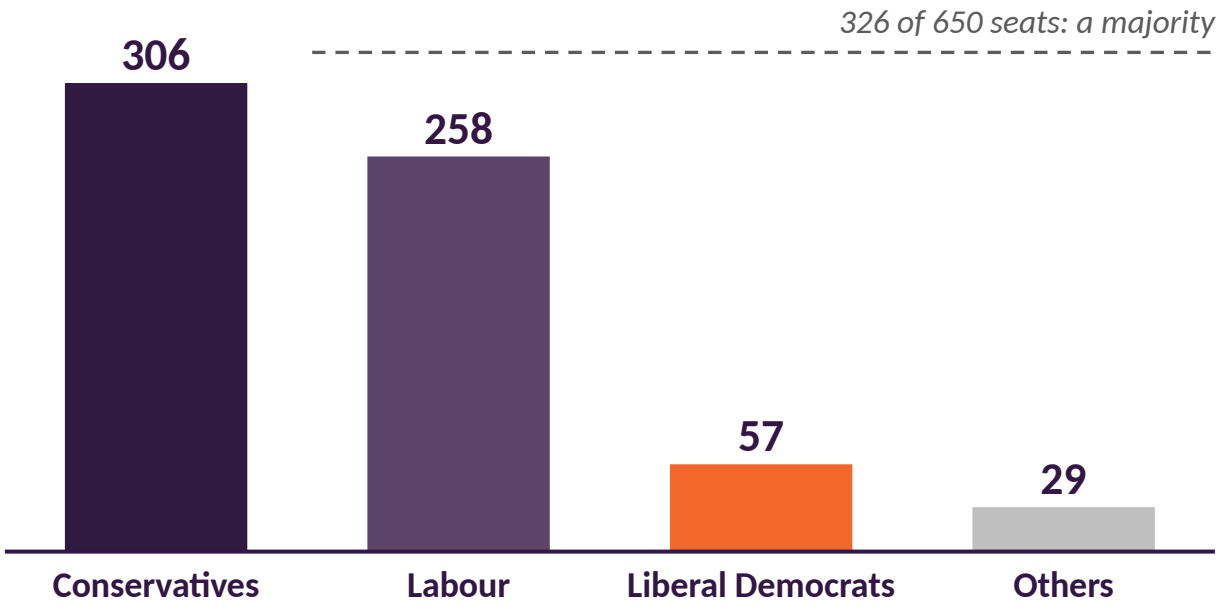
5 of 23: 22% of the cabinet with 16% of the seats

Ministries follow seats closely, and the smaller partner tends to get a little more than its share. The cabinet counts include the head of government.

Britain, May 2010: no party has a majority



Nick Clegg (Liberal Democrats), Gordon Brown (Labour, the prime minister) and David Cameron (Conservatives), the three party leaders



Conservatives + Liberal Democrats = 363

Labour + Liberal Democrats = 315

Labour + Liberal Democrats + four small parties = 328

Paddy Ashdown, a former Liberal Democrat leader: "our instincts go one way but the mathematics go the other."

The Liberal Democrats' options

You lead the Liberal Democrats, with 57 seats. One, two or three?

	SEATS	WHAT IT OFFERED	THE PROBLEM
1. A coalition with the Conservatives	363	Five seats in the cabinet, 20 ministers in all, and a referendum on the voting system	Their own voters preferred Labour, by 40% to 22%
2. A deal with Labour	315, or 328 with four small parties	Lib Dems closer to Labour on policy	"The arithmetic did not add up," and it kept a defeated government in office, required other parties
3. Support from outside	363 on votes of confidence and the budget	No ministers and no joint program	"The worst of all possible worlds": no influence, and still get blame

They chose the first, and Nick Clegg became Deputy PM to David Cameron.

The Liberal Democrats won 57 seats in 2010. How many did they win in 2015?

A	B	C	D
41	23	8	2

THE REFERENDUM

May 2011

- Their prize was a vote on a new electoral system
- 67.9% voted No

THE VOTERS

2010 to 2015

- Their share of the vote fell from 23.0% to 7.9%
- The Conservatives won a majority alone

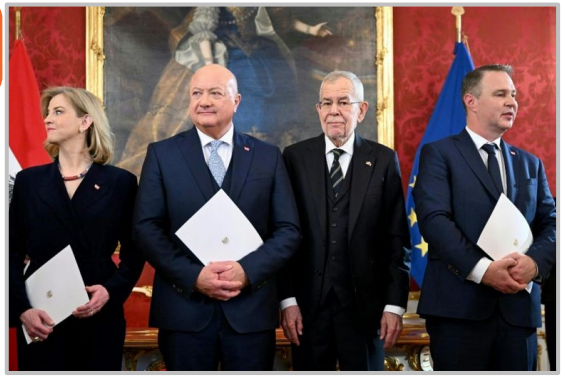
A WARNING FROM 2010

Ruth Fox, of Britain's Hansard Society

- "It will not take much for the party's future electoral prospects to be ravaged."

When a large party is ruled out

	THE PARTY LEFT OUT	WHAT REMAINED	THE RESULT
Germany, 2025	The AfD: second, with 152 of 630 seats	One two-party majority was left: CDU/CSU and SPD	The SPD, with 16% of the vote, took 7 of the 18 cabinet seats
The Netherlands, 2025	The PVV: joint first, with 26 of 150 seats	A broad coalition that the VVD refused, or 75 seats	A minority government, after 117 days
Austria, 2024	The Freedom Party: first, with 57 of 183 seats	No party would make its leader chancellor, and its own talks failed	Three other parties govern, after 155 days



Vienna, March 3, 2025: Christian Stocker (second from left), Austria's new chancellor, and the leaders of his two coalition partners with President Alexander Van der Bellen

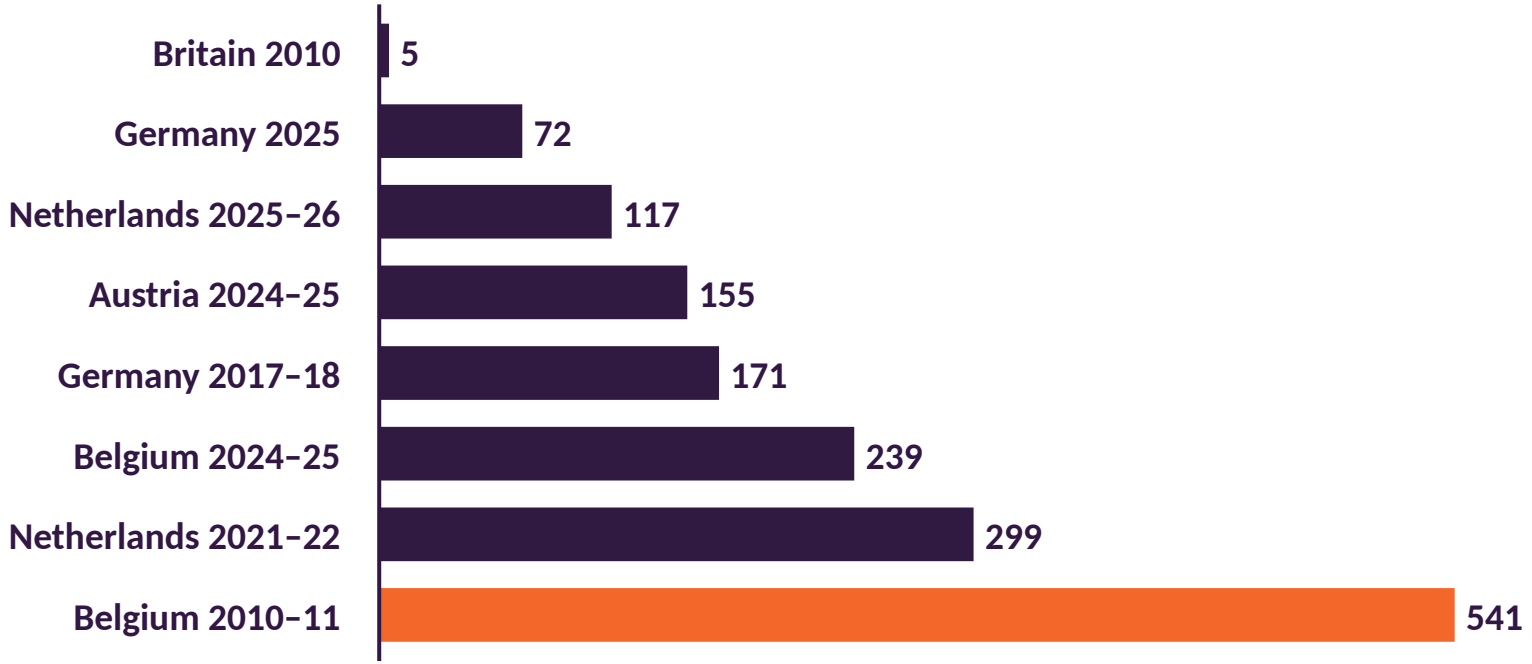
Who gains? The parties that remain. Each one is needed, so each can ask for more.

What results: grand coalitions, minority governments and three-party deals.

GUESS THE NUMBER

Britain took five days in 2010. How long did Belgium take in 2010–11?

A	B	C	D
54 days	154 days	341 days	541 days





Belgium: Flanders and Wallonia have separate parties, so every government is a coalition across the language line

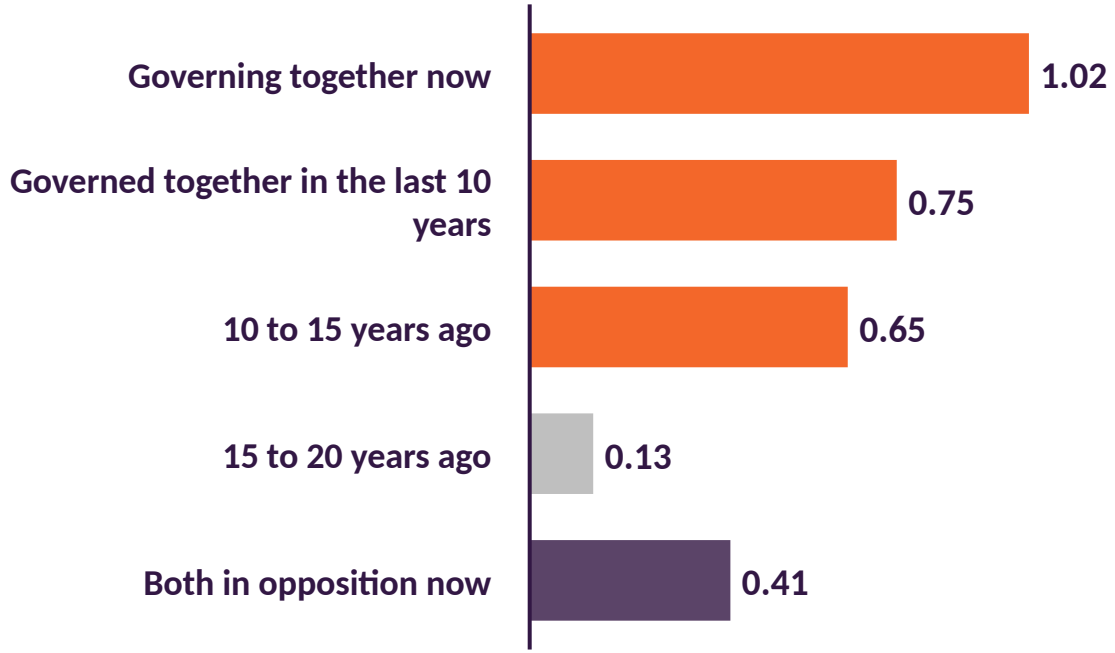
Days from the election to a new government taking office. Until then the old government stays on as a caretaker.

Coalition histories and polarization

THE ARGUMENT

- Most multi-party systems have dense histories of coalition partnerships
- Parties are never certain whom they might need to work with next
- That rewards “playing nice” and not burning bridges
- It could lower animosity between party elites, and between their voters

How much less do partisans dislike another party when the two parties have governed together?



This is what my co-authors and I find.

Reduction in dislike of the other party, holding the left–right distance between the two parties constant. The grey bar cannot be told apart from zero.

Governing Together

- A common program, agreed when the coalition forms
  - Britain, 2010: over 400 commitments and 29 policy reviews
- Laws follow the coalition’s compromise more than any one minister’s wishes
- Ministers share collective responsibility; when it fails, they feud in public
- A problem the program did not foresee can break a coalition



Olaf Scholz, chancellor of Germany, 2021–25. His three-party coalition collapsed in November 2024 over the budget

The FRC’s Government

Wednesday, October 21: what happened, and which account explains it?

What happened in our government?

	SEATS	IN THE GOVERNMENT?	MINISTRIES
Radical Left (RLP)	?	?	?
Social Democrats (SD)	?	?	?
Greens (GP)	?	?	?
Liberals (LP)	?	?	?
Christian Democrats (CD)	?	?	?
Populist Right (PR)	?	?	?

Prime Minister: ?

Vote of confidence, in seats: ?

Test 1: did the parties want office?

WHAT THE ACCOUNT PREDICTS

- The smallest coalition that reaches 51 seats
- Ministries split in proportion to seats
- The largest party in the coalition takes the Prime Minister

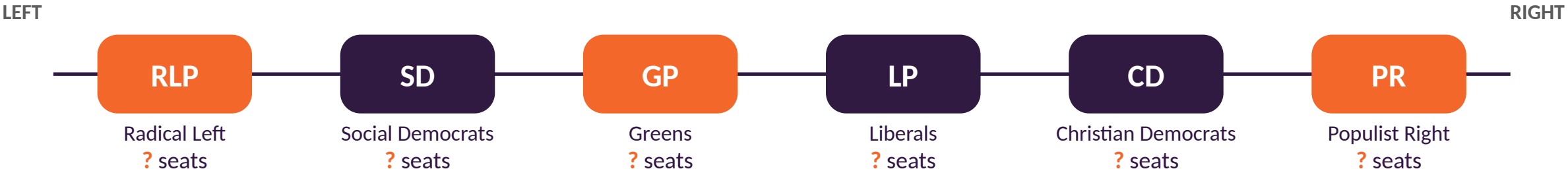
CHECK IT AGAINST THE RECORD

- Take any one party out of the government. Does it still have 51 seats?
- Each party's share of the coalition's seats, and its share of the ministries: do they match?
- Was there a smaller coalition that would have won? Why did it not form?

Does the office account explain the FRC's government? Yes | Partly | No

Whatever your answer: what in your negotiation record is the evidence?

Test 2: did the parties want policy?



WHAT THE ACCOUNT PREDICTS

- A coalition of neighbors on this line
- The party that holds the middle seats is in the government, and it sets the terms

CHECK IT AGAINST THE RECORD

- Are the governing parties next to each other?
- Count from the left: which party holds seats 50 and 51? Is it in the government?
- On each of the five issues, whose position is in the coalition agreement?

Does the policy account explain the FRC's government? Yes | Partly | No

Test 3: or was it something messier?

Three minutes in your caucus, with your negotiation records. Then one sentence from each party.

AN OFFER REFUSED

- Who offered what, to whom, and at what time?
- What happened next?

A RED LINE

- One that held
- One that did not hold

A SURPRISE

- What did nobody see coming?

Radical Left | **Social Democrats** | **Greens** | **Liberals** | **Christian Democrats** | **Populist Right**

Then the question for your memo: was it one of these that decided the government, or seats and policy after all?

The Debrief Memo

- No more than 1000 words
- Three parts: what happened; which account explains it; what the theory missed
- Compare what we did to what has happened in the real world
- Use this unit’s readings to make the case